Philosophy · Metaphysics of God

The Problem of Evil

Student workbook · the logical and evidential problems, Plantinga and Hick

This workbook goes alongside the two lesson presentations: **The Logical Problem of Evil** (and the free will response) and **The Evidential Problem of Evil** (Plantinga's reply and Hick's soul-making theodicy). Work through it one Part at a time. Every task can be completed from the slides and your class notes.

Name

Class / teacher

IN THIS WORKBOOK

1. Setting the scene — God's attributes and the core argument
2. Logical vs evidential; moral vs natural evil
3. Three ways to respond; theodicy vs defence
4. The free will theodicy and Plantinga's free will defence
5. Natural evil and the greater good
6. The evidential problem
7. Plantinga's reply to the evidential problem
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9. Who said what, and evaluation
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11. Progress check

How to use this workbook

Symbol	What it means
Short	One or two lines. A definition, a fact or a single step.

Symbol	What it means
Medium	Three to six lines. Explain a step and the reason for it.
Table	Fill in the empty cells. Use short phrases, not full paragraphs.
Sort / Order	Put the pieces in the right order or the right group.
Exam	Timed, exam-style question. Lined space is provided.

Key idea Missed a lesson? Every Part starts with a short **Recap** box. Read it, then go back to the matching slides before you try the tasks.

Part 01 Setting the scene

Recap

The central issue: does evil, as it actually occurs in this world, either prove that God — as traditionally conceived — does not exist, or at least make belief in such a God unreasonable?

The argument only bites because God's attributes are so demanding.

Task 1 · Table Complete the table of God's attributes.

Attribute	What it means	What it implies about evil
Supremely good		
Omnipotent		
Omniscient		

Task 2 · Order Rebuild the core argument. Write the label (P1–P4, C1–C3) next to each line, in the correct order.

Label	Statement
	So if such a God exists, evil does not exist.

Label	Statement
	If God is omnipotent, he is able to eliminate evil.
	Evil exists.
	If God is supremely good, he has the desire to eliminate evil.
	Therefore a supremely good, omnipotent, omniscient God does not exist.
	So if a supremely good, omnipotent, omniscient God exists, God will eliminate evil.
	If God is omniscient, he knows evil exists and knows how to eliminate it.

Task 3 · Short Which premise would a theist find easiest to challenge? Give one reason.

Part 02 Two versions, two types

Task 4 · Table Logical vs evidential: complete the comparison.

	The logical problem	The evidential problem
What it claims		
Is it deductive or inductive?		
Is it strong or weak claim?		
What a theist must do to defeat it?		

Task 5 · Short The logical problem says five claims cannot all be true. List them.

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____
4. _____
5. _____

Task 6 · Medium Explain the green cheese example. What does it show about the difference between 'logically possible' and 'reasonable to believe'?

Task 7 · Sort Moral evil, natural evil, or both? Tick and give a reason.

Example	Moral	Natural	Both	Reason
Ethnic cleansing				
An earthquake				
Disease				
Animal predation				
Famine that drives people to steal and kill				

Example	Moral	Natural	Both	Reason
Global warming				

Key idea Keep **both** types of evil in mind when you evaluate. Some responses solve moral evil but leave natural evil completely unanswered.

Part 03 How to respond

Task 8 · Table Three ways to respond to the problem of evil.

Response	What it does	Cost or difficulty
1 Give up a claim		
2 Offer a theodicy		
3 Offer a defence		

Task 9 · Table Theodicy or defence?

	Theodicy	Defence
What it claims		
What must be shown		
Example from the slides		

Task 10 · Medium Why is a **defence** enough to defeat the **logical** problem? Use the word 'contradiction'.

Part 04 Free will: theodicy and defence

Recap

The free will theodicy: free will is a great good. Without it our lives are not morally significant, and we could not freely enter a relationship with God. Being morally imperfect, we sometimes choose evil. Evil is the price of free will.

Task 11 · Medium **Objection:** why doesn't God simply make us choose the good? Explain the reply, using the word 'determined'.

Task 12 · Table Plantinga's key terms (God, Freedom and Evil).

Term	Plantinga's definition	My own example
Free		

Term	Plantinga's definition	My own example
Morally significant action		
Significantly free		
Moral evil		

Task 13 · Sort Is each action **morally significant**? Tick yes or no.

Action	Yes	No
Choosing a banana for breakfast		
Lying to a friend		
Helping someone who has fallen		
Choosing which colour pen to use		

Task 14 · Order Number Plantinga's free will defence in order (1–7).

Order	Statement
	So God cannot cause significantly free creatures to do only what is right.
	A world containing significantly free creatures is better than a world with no free creatures.
	If significantly free creatures were caused to do only what is right, they would not be free.

Order	Statement
	So God can only eliminate moral evil by eliminating the greater good of significant freedom.
	God can create significantly free creatures.
	So God cannot create a world with significantly free creatures that contains no evil.
	To be significantly free is to be capable of both moral good and moral evil.

Task 15 · Medium If C3 is asserted as **true**, the argument becomes a theodicy. Explain why Plantinga claims only that C3 is **possible** — and why that is enough.

Part 05 Natural evil and the greater good

> **Recap**
>
> Natural evil does not seem to have much to do with human free will. The slides give two responses: **Satan and demons** (Plantinga) and **necessary for a greater good**.

Task 16 · Table Two responses to natural evil.

	Satan and demons	Necessary for a greater good
What it says		
Claimed as true or only possible?		

	Satan and demons	Necessary for a greater good
One problem with it		

Task 17 · Table Suffering makes virtue possible. Complete each row.

Without…	…we could not have	Explain why
danger		
illness and poverty		
suffering		
temptation and the pull of selfishness		

Task 18 · Medium 'Without fear we might act well in danger — but it would take no more effort than eating when hungry.' Explain what this means.

Part 06 The evidential problem

Recap

The evidential problem concedes that God and evil are logically possible together. It claims only that, given our experience of evil, belief in an omnipotent, omniscient, supremely good God is **unreasonable**.

Task 19 · Table Amount, kind and distribution.

	What the claim is	Example from the slides
Amount		
Kind		
Distribution		

Task 20 · Sort Which does each example best illustrate — amount, kind or distribution? Some may fit more than one.

Example	Amount / kind / distribution	Why?
The Holocaust		
The tsunami of December 2004		
Innocent children suffering agonising deaths		

Example	Amount / kind / distribution	Why?
Those who have already suffered may suffer still more		
Animals eaten alive or with chronic illness		

Task 21 · Order Number the steps of 'the decisive move' (1–4).

Order	Step
	But are ALL these evils necessary? Is every one of them doing that work?
	The theist replies: without evil we could not be free, or develop virtues such as courage and compassion.
	A better world seems possible — with free will, virtue and some evil, but less. That is good reason to believe God does not exist.
	The evidential problem concedes it: some evil may well be necessary.

Part 07 Plantinga's reply

Task 22 · Table Plantinga's three possibilities — not three claims.

Possibility	In my own words
Moral evil could only be eliminated if free will were eliminated too.	
Natural evil is a form of moral evil (Satan and demons).	
This is the best possible world.	

Task 23 · Medium Against the evidential problem, possibility is not obviously enough. Explain Plantinga's further argument about **probability**.

Task 24 · Table Three objections to Plantinga.

Objection	What it says
1 He answers only the amount	
2 Is free will worth that much?	
3 Natural evil needs Satan	

Task 25 · Table Could God interfere selectively? Summarise each stage of the exchange.

Stage	Summary
Objection (the murder example)	
Reply	

Stage	Summary
Refinement (limited free will)	
Hick's response	

Part 08 Hick's soul-making theodicy

Recap

We should not think God has finished creating human beings. The world is a place of 'soul-making'.

Hick offers a **theodicy, not a defence**: he claims this is the true reason evil exists.

Task 26 · Table Two-stage creation.

	Stage one	Stage two
What happens		
Given or still under way?		
Individual or collective?		

Task 27 · Short Complete Hick's three examples.

We cannot be courageous unless _____.

We cannot be benevolent unless _____.

We cannot learn forgiveness unless _____.

Task 28 · Medium Which assumption about God does Hick **reject**? Why is a world of maximum pleasure and minimum pain 'no good' for us?

Task 29 · Table Why God could not simply make us good.

	Richer virtues	Authentic faith
Hick's point		
Key phrase		

Task 30 · Table Pain is not suffering.

	Pain	Suffering
What it is		
Why it matters		

Task 31 · Table Challenges to Hick and his replies.

Challenge	What it says	Hick's reply
Animal suffering		
Terrible evils		
Pointless evil		

Task 32 · Medium Explain **epistemic distance**. Why must the world be one we can understand 'as though God did not exist'?

Task 33 · Medium Why does Hick's theodicy need **life after death** and **universal salvation**? What follows if there are wasted lives?

Part 09 Who said what, and evaluation

Task 34 · Table Complete the scholars table without looking, then check against the slides.

Scholar	Theist or atheist?	Contribution
J. L. Mackie		
Alvin Plantinga		
Augustine		
John Hick		
Irenaeus		
William Rowe		

Task 35 · Table Strengths and weaknesses. Write the positive first, then the negative.

Response	In its favour	Against
Free will defence (logical problem)		

Response	In its favour	Against
Plantinga (evidential problem)		
Hick's soul-making theodicy		

Task 36 · Medium **Your verdict.** Is the problem of evil a decisive objection to the existence of God? Give separate verdicts for the logical and the evidential problem.

Part 10 Exam practice

How to answer

3 marks: a precise definition, no evaluation.

5 marks: a clear explanation with the steps in order.

12 marks: explanation (AO1), not evaluation. Name the version of the problem you are answering.

Short exam questions

37 Briefly explain what is meant by 'natural evil'. [3 marks]

38 Briefly explain what is meant by 'soul-making'. [3 marks]

39 Explain the logical problem of evil. [5 marks]

40 Explain the evidential problem of evil. [5 marks]

Part 10 12 mark question 41

Explain Plantinga's free will defence, and how it differs from a free will theodicy.

[12 marks]

Task 41a · Plan Plan your answer using the paragraph scaffold. Write key words only.

Paragraph	Key words for my answer
1 Set up	The logical problem · deductive
2 Distinguish	Theodicy = true reason · defence = consistent
3 Define	Free · morally significant · significantly free · moral evil
4 Argue	P1–C3 in order
5 Land it	Why possibility is enough

Task 41b · Exam Write your answer. Aim for about 25 minutes.

Self-check before you hand in

- ☐ I stated the logical problem and that it is deductive.
- ☐ I explained the difference between a theodicy and a defence.
- ☐ I defined Plantinga's terms and gave P1–C3 in order.
- ☐ I did not evaluate.

Part 10 12 mark question 42

Explain Hick's soul-making theodicy as a response to the evidential problem of evil. [12 marks]

Task 42a · Plan Plan your answer using the paragraph scaffold. Write key words only.

Paragraph	Key words for my answer
1 Set up	Amount, kinds, distribution · inductive
2 Frame it	A theodicy, not a defence
3 Explain	Two-stage creation · virtue requires evil
4 Apply	Epistemic distance · terrible evils · pointless evil
5 Complete it	Life after death · universal salvation

Task 42b · Exam Write your answer. Aim for about 25 minutes.

Self-check before you hand in

- ☐ I stated the evidential problem and that it is inductive.
- ☐ I explained two-stage creation and why virtue requires evil.
- ☐ I showed how Hick answers the evidential challenges.
- ☐ I mentioned life after death and universal salvation, and did not evaluate.

Part 10 12 mark question 43

Explain the evidential problem of evil and Plantinga's response to it. [12 marks]

Task 43a · Plan Plan your answer using the paragraph scaffold. Write key words only.

Paragraph	Key words for my answer
1 The evidential problem	
2 Amount, kind, distribution	
3 A better world was possible	
4 Plantinga's three possibilities	
5 The probability argument	

Task 43b · Exam Write your answer. Aim for about 25 minutes.

Self-check before you hand in

- ☐ I made clear the argument is inductive and about unnecessary evil.
- ☐ I gave a concrete illustration.
- ☐ I explained why possibility alone is not obviously enough.
- ☐ I explained Plantinga's argument about probability, and did not evaluate.

Part 11 Progress check

Task 44 · Table Rate your confidence now (1 = not yet, 3 = secure). Go back to the matching Part for any 1s.

I can…	Part	1	2	3
set out the core argument P1–C3	1			
explain logical vs evidential, and moral vs natural evil	2			
explain the difference between a theodicy and a defence	3			
set out Plantinga's free will defence in order	4			
explain two responses to natural evil	5			
explain amount, kind and distribution	6			
explain Plantinga's reply and the objections to it	7			
explain Hick's theodicy and his three replies	8			
match each scholar to their contribution	9			

Task 45 · Medium The one thing I still find hardest is… and my plan to fix it is…